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Save the Species

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Save The Species Game Design Document

Version: 1.0

1. Overview

1.1 Tagline: *“Survive, grow, and protect your species in the world’s most endangered rainforest.”*

1.2 High Concept: A survival board game where players become endangered animals racing to adulthood in the Amazon, navigating a landscape of enriching resources and devastating man-made hazards.

1.3 Short Description: Save The Species is an educational board game where each player embodies an endangered Amazonian animal. Players navigate a segmented game board, progressing from infancy to adulthood. Through strategic movement, luck, and answering conservation-based quiz questions, players overcome environmental hazards and human conflicts, learning about the very real threats of deforestation and the importance of biodiversity along the way.

Players: Two - Five players

2. Target Audience

2.1 Age Range: 8 years and up.

Demographics:

- Students to elementary to middle school science classes
- Families seeking educational game nights
- Educators and homeschooling groups
- Casual board game enthusiasts interested in nature and conservation

2.2 Player Types Catered To:

- **Explorers:** Enjoy discovering fun facts about the animals and the rainforest
- **Achievers:** Focused on the goal of reaching adulthood and winning the game.
- **Socializers:** Learn through discussion and quiz mechanics

3. Genre & Platform

Genre: Educational/ Strategy

Platform: Physical Tabletop Game

4. Mechanics and Rules

4.1 Core Objective: Be the first player to guide your animal token from the "Baby/Child" stage to the "Adult" stage by landing exactly on the required Heart Tiles, while surviving hazards and learning about conservation.

4.2 Game Components:

- **Game Board:** A linear or winding track divided into three distinct, color-coded sections:
 - Section 1: Baby/Child Stage
 - Section 2: Teenage Stage
 - Section 3: Adult Stage
- **Animal Tokens:** (5 unique tokens)
 - Brown-Headed Spider Monkey
 - Harpy Eagle
 - South American Tapir
 - Great Green Macaw
 - Green Iguana

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- Movement:
 - Six Sided Die
- Card Decks:
 - Fun Fact Cards: General Amazon facts and specific animal facts.
 - Hazard Cards: Describe specific threats (e.g., hunters, fires, illness).
- Special Tiles: Integrated into the board track.
 - ★ Star Tile: Draw a Fun Fact card.
 - ❤ Heart Tile: Draw a Fun Fact card. *Landing exactly on this tile is required to advance to the next section.*
 - ⚠ Hazard Triangle Tile: Triggers a hazard event.
 - 🌿 Leaf Tile: Wildlife Sanctuary. Player rolls the die again for extra movement.

4.3 Core Gameplay Loop:

1. Setup: Players choose an animal token and start on the first tile of Section 1. Each player draws one general Amazon fact and one fact about their chosen animal.
2. Turn Sequence:
 - Roll the die and move your token forward that many spaces.
 - Resolve the effect of the tile you land on.
 - Play passes to the left.
3. Section Progression: To leave Section 1 or Section 2, a player must roll the *exact number* to land on a Heart Tile. Upon doing so, they move their token to the start of the next section on their next turn.
4. Winning the Game: The first player to land on the final Heart Tile in Section 3 (Adulthood) wins the game.

4.4 Detailed Tile Mechanics:

- Hazard Tile (⚠): When a player lands here, they roll the die:

- Roll 1-4: Draw a Hazard Card and follow its instructions (e.g., move back, lose a turn).
 - Roll 5-6: Other players may quiz the active player on any Fun Fact card they have collected. If answered correctly, the hazard is avoided. If incorrect, draw a Hazard Card
-
- Star Tile (★): When a player lands here, they draw a fun fact card pertaining to either the Amazon or their specific animal.
 - Heart Tile (♥): When a player lands here, they draw a fun fact card pertaining to either the Amazon or their specific animal.
 - The player advances to the next section of the game board.
 - Leaf Tile (🌿): When a player lands here, they get to roll the die again and move the amount of spaces of the number that was rolled.

4.5 Section Progression:

To leave Section 1 or Section 2, a player must roll the *exact number* to land on a Heart Tile. Upon doing so, they move their token to the start of the next section on their next turn.

5. Narrative & Setting

5.1 Story Premise:

The year is 2025. The Amazon Rainforest, a vital ecosystem, is under relentless threat from deforestation, pollution, and human expansion. Players are born into this fragile world as endangered animals. Their journey is a struggle for survival against man-made and natural obstacles.

5.2 Characters:

The players themselves are the characters, embodied as one of five endangered species, each with unique traits and fun facts that personalize the experience.

5.3 Progression & World-Building:

The three sections of the board mirror the life stages of an animal, creating a personal narrative arc for each player. The hazards are not random monsters but real-world threats (farmers, hunters, pollution), grounding the game in a powerful and relevant environmental context.

6. Serious Purpose / Learning Objective

The primary purpose of "Save The Species" is to educate players about:

- **Biodiversity:** The unique roles and characteristics of specific Amazonian species.
- **Ecosystems:** The interconnectedness of life in the Amazon Rainforest.
- **Conservation Threats:** The direct causes and devastating effects of deforestation, poaching, and pollution.
- **Empathy:** Fostering a sense of connection and responsibility towards endangered species and their habitats.

7. How Gameplay Reinforces Learning

7.1 Intrinsic Integration: Knowledge is not a separate trivia element; it is a core game mechanic. Remembering fun facts (Explorer appeal) can directly help you survive hazards, providing a tangible reward for learning.

7.2 Experiential Learning: Players don't just read about a forest fire; they "die" in one and are sent back to the start, creating a memorable, emotional understanding of the threat's severity.

7.3 **Repeated Exposure:** The tile and card systems ensure players are constantly exposed to new facts and reminded of previous ones through the quiz mechanic, reinforcing retention.

7.4 **Discussion Catalyst:** The game naturally prompts conversations between players, parents, and educators about the issues presented on the cards.

8. Art and Aesthetic Direction

8.1 **Art Style:** Vibrant, stylized, and approachable cartoon realism. The art should be engaging for children but detailed enough to respect the subject matter.

8.2 **Tone:** The game balances a sense of adventure and wonder with moments of tension and the sobering reality of environmental threats. The overall tone is hopeful and empowering, not bleak.

8.3 **Color Palette:**

- Section 1 (Baby): A hopeful sunny yellow.
- Section 2 (Teen): A vibrant, adventurous orange.
- Section 3 (Adult): A bold, warning red.

8.4 **User Interface (Board & Components):**

- The board is visually rich, illustrating a path through a dense rainforest canopy, riverbanks, and forest floor.
- Tile borders are color-coded and use clear, intuitive icons (Star, Heart, etc.).
- Card design is clean with easy-to-read text.

9. Prototype and Technical Notes

9.1 Current Stage: Conceptual Design / Early Prototyping.

9.2 Tools Used: Canva digital art software, Physical Paper

9.3 Key Design Challenges:

- Balance: Ensuring the game is challenging but not frustrating. The "exact roll" mechanic for progression is a key risk/reward element to test.
- Pacing: Managing game length so it remains engaging for the target age group.
- Information Density: Presenting fun facts in a concise, memorable way without overwhelming players.

10. Testing and Feedback Summary

Key Issues & Solutions

★ Confusing Setup and Rules

- **Problem:** Players struggled to start and found rules overwhelming.
- **Solutions:**
 - Create a "Quick Start Guide": One page with the setup and core turn sequence.
 - Improve Rule Book Structure: Break rules into clear sections:
 - Goal of the Game
 - Setup (with Pictures)
 - On Your Turn (3 steps)
 - Tile Types
 - Winning the Game
 - Standardize Card Types: Color Code Card
 - Green Border - Amazon Rainforest Facts
 - Red Border with Hazard Symbol - Hazard Cards
 - Species-Specific Color - Animal Fact Card

★ **Poor Scaling & Identification**

- **Problem:** Board too small, pieces too big, hard to distinguish characters
- **Solutions:**
 - **Larger Board:** Increase the board size especially to accommodate the larger, clearer tiles
 - **Color-Coded System:**
 - Each animal has a matching color token
 - Matching color to the animal fact card
 - **Distinct Tokens:** Use animal miniatures

★ **Lack Player Interaction**

- **Problem:** Felt like separate solitaire games
- **Solutions:**
 - **Add Cooperative Elements:**
 - If players land on the same tile, all draw extra fact card
 - Hazard cards that affect all players within 3 space radius
 - **Add Competitive Interactions:**
 - Land on another player – quiz battle – winner moves forward 2 spaces
 - Trade fact cards for movement bonuses

★ **Weak Quiz Mechanic**

- **Problem:** Quiz was "unattractive" and felt abstract
- **Solutions:**
 - **Make Quizzes Meaningful**
 - **Correct** – move forward 1 space
 - **Incorrect** – stay
 - **Expert** (Collect 3 facts) – gain a special ability

★ **Abrupt Game End & Weak Progression**

- **Problem:** No climax, sudden ending
- **Solutions:**
 - **Challenges/Trials:** To earn the progression off more than luck
 - To progress, must complete “Coming of Age Trial” or “Adult Trial”
 - Answer questions such as ones that a teenager of the animal must know to survive, etc.
 - **Progression Milestones:**
 - **Reach Teen:** Gain special ability
 - **Reach Adult:** Gain advantage in Adult Trial

★ **Disconnected Learning**

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- **Problem:** Facts didn't affect gameplay
 - **Solutions:**
 - **Integrate Knowledge:**
 - Certain facts give one-time bonuses
 - Matching animal + habitat facts = extra move
 - **Movement Choices:**
 - Spend turns learning facts instead of movement
 - Share facts with others for a bonus
 - If the student remembers the fact in the next round you both earn a bonus
- ★ **Clarify Hazard Movements**
 - **Problem:** Confusion about tile effects vs. card effects
 - **Solutions:**
 - **Clear Sequence: (Part of the Improved rule book)**
 - Land on Hazard tile
 - Roll Die
 - If 1-4: Draw Hazard Card
 - If 5-6: Take Quiz
 - **Simplify Hazard Effects:** Reduce penalties
 -

Revisions and Iterations

- Game Mechanics Edit
 - ★ Star Tile: Draw a Fun Fact card about the Amazon rainforest.
 - 🌿 Leaf Tile: Wildlife Sanctuary. Draw a Fun Fact card about the animal. Player rolls the die again for extra movement.

11. Game Credits

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Appendices

Appendix A: Complete Fun Fact & Lifespan Database

- ❖ <https://animaldiversity.org/> - Database for animal life spans
- ❖ https://docs.google.com/document/d/11cve_EWEVfKY-OIRkIzeoLi37G1Zom91ymoHAUBF65c/edit?tab=t.o - Fun Fact List & sources

Appendix B: Comprehensive Hazard Card List

Hazards

1. A trophy hunter had appeared and is aiming for you
 - a. Run back 3 tiles to lose the hunter (or as many as possible)
2. A soybean farmer is burning down a segment of the forest for more farm space
 - a. Go back to start of the board because you die in that fire
3. A predator is around you and it's very hungry
 - a. Run back to the start of your section to lose the predator
4. Territorial dispute between animals
 - a. Run back 3 squares to avoid this dispute (or as many as possible)
5. Can't find any food to sustain yourself
 - a. Run back 2 squares to find some food
6. You ate bad food and became ill
 - a. Roll a die, if it is even you lose a turn, odd you die and begin at the beginning of the board
7. An oil spill appeared and contaminated all your drinking water
 - a. Go back 4 squares (or as many as possible) and lose 2 turns

❖ https://www.canva.059173com/design/DAG38Lo_QQA/-zEnqQHUzcCwcITJ_5IXOO/edit?utm_content=DAG38Lo_QQA&utm_campaign=designshare&utm_medium=link2&utm_source=sharebutton -

[illegible]

Movement - To move your piece inside of the game roll a dice and then move the number of tiles shown on the dice

- Star – Draw a fun fact card
- Heart – Draw a fun fact card and gain the ability to go to the next section
- Hazard – roll a dice. If the dice lands on 1-4 draw a card from the hazard card deck and follow what it says. Otherwise if it lands on 5-6 other players can quiz you on your fun fact cards. If answered correctly you are not punished otherwise draw a hazard card
- Leaf – Extra movement; he ability to roll the dice again this turn for more movement

Appendix D: Animal Icons

Baby Version, Teen Version, Adult Version (In Order)

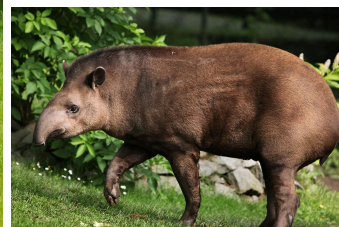
- Brown-Headed Spider Monkey



- Harpy Eagle



- South American Tapir



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- Great Green Macaw



- Green Iguana

